



PSN messenger

Playstation launched an app on iOS and Android to message your buddies on PSN. That's one more way to talk to the same set of people. <http://dgit.in/PSNmessages>



Digital Puppet of Tom

Tom Hanks' digital puppet does things he *ahem* couldn't do on screen. <http://dgit.in/TomHnksPupp>

Inbox

LETTER OF THE MONTH #1

✉ Hi Siddharth my gaming story is tied in with the editorials by Jayesh (tech journey) and Robert (addictions) in the November issue. My profile: 55 years old, no kids, working in a MNC as middle manager and staying in Kandivali, Mumbai. I'm an avid wargamer and have even written for the last regular issue of SKOAR! which was a special on World War 2 games. I love the look on the faces of the sales guys when I walk into a shop, ask for games and am inevitably presented with the query, "How old is your child"? to which I invariably reply "50+".

I'm standing in front of the shrinking PC section. The shelves don't have the kind of stuff that got me hooked to gaming years ago – wargames with regular strategy. (Yes, I know Counter Strike is a strategy game, but then...) I settle for *Civilization* and that classic *Age of Empires III* (Duh, I told you I was old). I have a backup copy of the latter in case the one that's being played regularly by my equally 50+ wife goes bad (I got her hooked on to *Age of Empires* so that she can leave me alone to play my favourites).

My digital journey began back in the year 1987 when I tried my hands at programming. I left the company, but not before acquiring a healthy respect for WordStar and Lotus 1-2-3 (Did I say I was 50+?).

Marriage and 10 years later, it's the late 1990s and I have my own PC. WS and Lotus are now history and replaced by 'Word', 'Excel' and 'Powerpoint,' which neither has the power nor does it make a point. I walked into Crossword and saw a discounted "3-in-1" pack of

strategy games. The first game I ever played was Steel Panthers – a turn-based strategy game. Hooked. Forever. (The other two were Talonsoft's *Battle of Bulge* and Sid Meier's *Gettysburg* – both of which I sadly threw away without knowing the lineage of the developers.) Since then, I've been hooked to authentic war games played from a general's eye view.



I spent (and still spend) an inordinate amount of time hunting down obscure titles paid and free such as *Panzer General* and *Fleet Command* and Talonsoft's games. My first ever RTS was *Fleet Command* – most of the others are turn-based. My utterly favorite RTS games are *Company of Heroes* and *Ardennes Offensive* (downloaded from Steam). I found the gameplay of *World of Conflict* and *Codename Panzers: Cold War* incredibly immersive and enjoyable. Having faced online ignominy, I continue to play against the computer – as and when my job allows (Last night was nirvana – *CoHI* for three hours till 1 a.m.)

I still prefer PC games. Why should I pay more for dedicated hardware when I already have a PC with a GeForce graphic card and 2TB hard disk? I still prefer to sit with an old fashioned physical book (I hate all e-readers), with my favorite track playing on my old fashioned music system (dedicated audio CD player, amplifier and speakers). Convergence may be in right now, but then I'm quite divergent (Pun intended. Yes, I saw the movie).

–K V Ramesh

📧 Your letter was one of the most interesting ones we've ever received.

I totally agree with you about what passes off as strategy gaming these days. You can rest assured none of us here think Counter Strike is strategy :-)

To this day, I play classics such as *WC3*, *Red Alert 2* and *Homeworld* (Did you check out the remake?) and Activision's 1998 *Battlezone*. The last one on that list takes the cold war to the moon. A story unlike any I've seen till date. You'll like it – it takes the "general's eye view" that you're familiar with to the front lines. So while you control the battlefield you're also one of the players, i.e. you're able to see through that character's first person view and fight shoulder to shoulder with your comrades. This was an unheard of concept in 1999 when I discovered the game.

Coming to your journey with PCs, software and computing, surprisingly I too can relate. Dbase for example brings back memories. I was too young to experience it in real-world scenarios, but I did study it academically :-). Executing copy commands in DOS to copy games on floppies too. Also I've never read a better descriptor for PowerPoint. Hahaha.

P.S. Most of the games you've mentioned I've not even heard of, to be honest. However, my next move is to hit them up in Steam or hunt down some of the more obscure ones on a DOS games archive I've depended on from time-to-time.

PPS. I've eaten humble pie playing my favourite games online too. But it's fun to experience the skill level out there.

PPPS. Go for the Chromecast. With Plex, it will just make watching content much easier.

Drop by our office sometime. You'll find people about half your age, but kindred spirits nonetheless.

–Siddharth

philes? There are many ways in which authorities can actually do a better job of keeping you safe with more access to data. It's where to draw the line that the debate is about, and I don't think either extreme is right (total privacy vs no privacy). I don't know about the Fast Track

suggestion, but I can certainly write a time travel dmystify (though it would be less science and more science fiction). Let's see how much positive feedback we receive for this suggestion of yours. If we do, consider it done.

–Robert

✉ I'm a big fan of your magazine. Here are my suggestions:

1. Please update your DVD UI. I think it's very old now and seriously needs a minor reboot.
2. In the next issue, can you provide a Fast Track or tutorial on the Adobe